

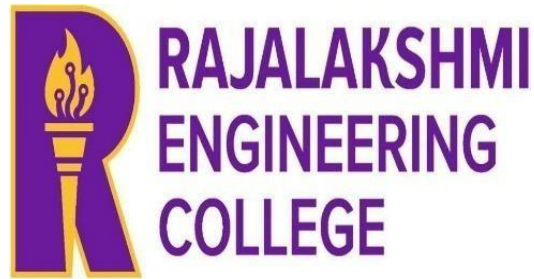
FILM MAKING AND RADIO PODCASTING CD23731
REPORT

Submitted by

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BONAFIDE CERTIFICATE

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ABSTRACT

Side Effects is a short film in the emotional and social-message genre that follows a young man through the emotional aftermath of his best friend's murder. Rather than dramatizing the crime itself, the film focuses entirely on the psychological and behavioral consequences of sudden, violent loss — the “side effects” of grief — as the protagonist descends into smoking, drug use, obsessive physical training and a fixation on revenge.

The film's turning point arrives through an unexpected phone call from a film director, who reveals that the protagonist's late friend had always dreamed of becoming a director and had wanted him to be part of that dream. Confronted with this revelation, the protagonist discards the instruments of his destructive coping and chooses instead to carry his friend's dream forward, completing an arc from grief and anger to purposeful transformation.

This report documents the complete production of Side Effects, including the development of its story, theme and characters; the pre-production, production and post-production methodology followed, including editing in CapCut; a scene-by-scene analysis of the finished film; and a reflective evaluation of its outcomes, challenges and learning value. The report concludes with the project's key takeaways and possible directions for future enhancement.

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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Overview

Short-form filmmaking has become one of the most accessible and expressive mediums for young creators to communicate ideas within a compressed running time. Within three to five minutes, a short film must establish character, conflict, a turning point and a resolution without the narrative space available to a feature production. This report documents the conception, development and production of the short film Side Effects, a drama with an emotional and social-message orientation that traces a young man's journey from grief and destructive coping to purposeful transformation. The report captures the creative reasoning behind the story, the practical steps followed during production and post-production, and a reflective evaluation of the completed film.

1.2 Background of Short Film Production

Short films occupy a distinct space within visual storytelling. Unlike feature-length productions, they depend on economy of expression: every scene, line of dialogue and visual choice must contribute directly to the central idea. Accessible mobile-editing tools such as Cap-Cut have lowered the barrier for independent creators to produce polished short-form content without large production budgets, allowing individual filmmakers to explore personal or socially relevant themes such as grief, addiction and redemption in a format that can be written, shot and edited relatively quickly. Side Effects was developed within this tradition of concise, emotionally driven independent short filmmaking.

1.3 Concept of the Film

The concept of Side Effects centres on the psychological aftermath of sudden, violent loss. Rather than presenting the murder of the protagonist's friend as a mystery to be solved, the film focuses entirely on the internal and behavioural consequences the loss produces in the protagonist. The title operates on two levels: it refers literally to the destructive "side effects" of grief substance use, anger and a desire for revenge while also gesturing toward the idea that pain, when redirected, can produce a different kind of consequence: purpose and growth.

1.4 Problem Theme Addressed

The film addresses how unprocessed grief can lead a person toward self-destructive and potentially violent behaviour, and how an unexpected opportunity can redirect that trajectory. It engages with a recognisable social concern young people responding to trauma through substance use and retaliation rather than healthy emotional processing and by dramatizing this arc within a compact narrative, invites the viewer to consider what alternatives exist to destructive coping.

1.5 Motivation

The motivation for producing Side Effects was to create a short, emotionally resonant narrative that could communicate a meaningful message about grief and transformation within a strict runtime. Short-form drama offers an opportunity to practise compressed storytelling establishing a protagonist's emotional state, escalating conflict and delivering a resolution while working within realistic production constraints. The project was also motivated by an interest in how a single unexpected event can serve as a turning point that redirects a character's destructive arc toward something constructive.

1.6 Objectives

- Write and structure a short-film script capable of conveying a complete emotional arc within a 3–5 minute runtime.
- Translate the script into a scene-by-scene and shot-by-shot production plan.
- Shoot and direct the four core scenes depicting loss, destructive coping, an unexpected turning point and realization.
- Edit the footage using Cap-Cut into a coherent, well-paced short film.
- Critically reflect on the finished film's ability to communicate its intended theme and moral.

1.7 Scope of the Project

The scope of the project covers the complete short-film production pipeline as applied to a single 3–5 minute narrative film: concept development, scriptwriting, scene and shot planning, production and post-production editing in Cap-Cut. The scope does not extend to festival submission or distribution strategy; the project was carried out at the scale appropriate to an independent short production.

1.8 Significance of the Film

Side Effects is significant both as a creative exercise in compressed narrative filmmaking and as a piece of social-message cinema. It demonstrates how a short runtime can still accommodate a complete emotional journey loss, descent and transformation without sacrificing clarity or impact. The film's moral, that grief and anger can destroy a person but that turning pain into purpose can give life new meaning, gives the project relevance beyond a technical exercise.

1.9 Organisation of the Report

This report is organised into five chapters. Chapter 1 introduces the project, its background, motivation, objectives and scope. Chapter 2 discusses the story, concept and creative development of Side Effects. Chapter 3 presents the production methodology followed, covering pre-production, production and post-production. Chapter 4 provides a scene-by-scene analysis of the film and an evaluation of the finished work. Chapter 5 concludes the report and discusses possible future enhancements.

Table 1.1 Project Information

Requirement	Details
Short Film Title	Side Effects
Duration	3–5 minutes
Genre	Drama / Emotional / Social Message
One-Line Story	After his best friend is murdered, a grieving young man turns to addiction and revenge, but an unexpected opportunity helps him transform his pain into fulfilling his friend's dream.
Moral	Grief and anger can destroy a person, but turning pain into purpose can give life a new meaning.
Camera Used	iPhone 16e Camera
Video Editing Software	Cap-Cut

CHAPTER 2

STORY, CONCEPT AND CREATIVE DEVELOPMENT

2.1 Introduction

This chapter documents the creative development of Side Effects, from its initial concept through to its finished narrative structure. It explains how the story was conceived, how the theme and moral were embedded into the plot, and how the characters and scenes were shaped to serve the film's emotional arc.

2.2 Story Concept

The story concept for Side Effects was built around a single dramatic question: what happens to a person's inner life after his closest friend is murdered, and what if anything can pull him back from the destructive path that grief opens up? The concept deliberately avoids procedural or investigative elements; the murder itself is not dramatized or explained. Instead, the film stays entirely with the protagonist's emotional and behavioural response, allowing the "side effects" of the loss to become the true subject of the story.

2.3 One-Line Story

The film's one-line story is: "After his best friend is murdered, a grieving young man turns to addiction and revenge, but an unexpected opportunity helps him transform his pain into fulfilling his friend's dream." This single sentence captures the film's full arc loss, destructive response, turning point and transformation and served as the guiding reference throughout scripting and production.

2.4 Synopsis

The film opens with the protagonist receiving news of his best friend's murder. Overwhelmed by grief, he descends into destructive coping smoking, drug use, obsessive physical training and a growing fixation on revenge. His resolve to "take revenge" marks the lowest point of his emotional arc. The story turns when he receives an unexpected call from a film director, who reveals that the protagonist's late friend had always dreamed of becoming a director and had wanted his friend to be part of that dream. Confronted with this revelation, the protagonist discards the cigarette and drugs that had come to symbolise his grief, and picks up a camera or

script instead, choosing to carry his friend's dream forward. The film closes on this moment of realization, with the title *Side Effects* appearing over a cut to black.

2.5 Theme and Central Idea

The central idea of the film is that grief, when left unprocessed, produces destructive “side effects” anger, addiction and a desire for revenge but that the same emotional intensity can be redirected into something meaningful when the right opportunity or perspective appears. The film treats grief not as an endpoint but as a force that can be channelled in either a destructive or a constructive direction, depending on what the grieving person is offered and how they choose to respond.

2.6 Genre

Side Effects is classified as a drama with an emotional and social-message orientation. It relies on internal character conflict and a compact emotional arc rather than external plot mechanics such as mystery or action, positioning it within the tradition of message-driven short dramas.

2.7 Moral and Social Message

The film's moral is stated directly: “Grief and anger can destroy a person, but turning pain into purpose can give life a new meaning.” This moral is delivered through the protagonist's own transformation rather than through explicit narration, allowing the audience to draw the message from his actions discarding the instruments of his destructive coping and picking up the tools of his friend's dream instead.

2.8 Title Significance – “SIDE EFFECTS”

The title *Side Effects* operates on multiple levels. Literally, it evokes the unintended consequences of grief: the smoking, drug use and revenge-seeking that emerge as “side effects” of unprocessed loss. Figuratively, it can also be read as pointing toward the film's resolution that even devastating loss can produce an unexpected, positive “side effect” when the protagonist's pain is transformed into purpose. This dual meaning is reinforced by the film's structure, in which Scene 2 is explicitly named “The Side Effects” and shows the protagonist's destructive behaviour in a rapid montage.

2.9 Character Development

The protagonist is developed almost entirely through action and behaviour rather than expository dialogue, in keeping with the compressed short-film format. He begins the story in a settled emotional state that is shattered by the phone call announcing his friend's murder. His subsequent behaviour smoking, drug use, intense physical training and declarations of revenge establishes him as a character overtaken by grief and anger. The turning point, delivered through the director's phone call, reveals a second dimension to his character: his loyalty to his friend and his capacity to redirect his emotional intensity once given a meaningful outlet. His final action discarding the cigarette and drugs and picking up a camera or script completes his arc from destructive grief to purposeful transformation.

2.10 Narrative Structure

The narrative follows a compact four-scene structure that mirrors a classical dramatic arc within a short runtime: Scene 1 establishes the inciting incident (the loss); Scene 2 depicts rising action through destructive coping (the side effects); Scene 3 introduces the turning point (the unexpected call); and Scene 4 delivers the climax and resolution (realization and transformation). This structure allows the film to deliver a complete emotional journey without requiring an extended scene count, which is essential given the 3–5 minute duration constraint.

2.11 Emotional Journey of the Protagonist

The protagonist's emotional journey moves through a clear sequence: loss, grief, anger, destructive behaviour, a desire for revenge, an unexpected opportunity, realization, purpose and transformation. Each stage is represented by a specific visual or dramatic beat in the script the phone call for loss, the montage for destructive behaviour, the director's call for the unexpected opportunity, and the final gesture of discarding the cigarette and drugs for realization and transformation. This progression forms the emotional backbone of the film and is examined scene by scene in Chapter 4.

2.12 Scene Development

Each of the film's four scenes was developed to serve a specific function within the protagonist's emotional arc. Scene 1 ("The Loss") is brief and immediate, delivering the

inciting incident through a single phone call. Scene 2 (“The Side Effects”) uses a montage structure to compress the passage of time and show multiple forms of destructive coping without slowing the film’s pace. Scene 3 (“The Unexpected Call”) is built around a single piece of revelatory dialogue that reframes the protagonist’s understanding of his friend and his own possible future. Scene 4 (“Realization”) is deliberately quiet and visual, relying on the protagonist’s physical actions looking at the cigarette and drugs, then at the photograph, then discarding them to deliver the film’s emotional payoff without additional dialogue.

2.13 Script Development

The script for Side Effects was written to be delivered almost entirely through visual action and minimal, direct dialogue, a deliberate choice suited to the short-film format. Each scene contains only the dialogue necessary to advance its emotional beat the caller’s announcement in Scene 1, the protagonist’s declaration of revenge in Scene 2, the director’s revelation in Scene 3, and the protagonist’s final line in Scene 4 Your dream will live on through me. This economy of dialogue keeps the film within its 3–5 minute duration while still delivering a complete narrative and emotional arc.

Table 2.1 Character Description

Character	Role in the Story
Protagonist (Hero)	Grieving young man who moves from destructive coping toward purposeful transformation; the film’s central character.
Deceased Friend	The protagonist’s murdered best friend, whose unfulfilled dream of becoming a director becomes the mechanism for the protagonist’s transformation.
Caller (Scene 1)	Delivers the news of the friend’s murder, triggering the protagonist’s grief.
Director (Scene 3)	Offers the protagonist an opportunity connected to his late friend’s dream, serving as the story’s turning point.

CHAPTER 3

SHORT FILM PRODUCTION METHODOLOGY

3.1 Introduction

This chapter documents the production methodology followed in creating SIDE EFFECTS, covering pre-production planning, the production / shooting process and the post-production editing workflow. As with any short-film project, the methodology moves from planning through execution to refinement, with each stage building on decisions made in the one before it.

3.2 Pre-Production

Pre-production for Side Effects involved finalising the script, breaking it into its four constituent scenes, and identifying the shots required to convey each scene's emotional beat. Because each scene serves a distinct narrative function loss, destructive coping, the turning point and realization pre-production planning focused on ensuring that the visual treatment of each scene supported its function, for example planning the montage structure of Scene 2 to compress multiple destructive behaviours into a short screen time.

3.3 Script Planning

Script planning followed the story beats established during the creative-development stage described in Chapter 2, translating the one-line story and synopsis into scene headings, brief action description and minimal dialogue. Priority was given to keeping each scene's dialogue and action tight, given the constraint of a 3–5 minute total runtime.

3.4 Scene Planning

Each of the four scenes was planned individually. Scene 1 was planned as a short, emotionally direct scene centred on a phone call. Scene 2 was planned as a montage requiring several short shots smoking, drug use, working out, looking at the photograph intercut to convey the passage of time and escalating destructive behaviour. Scene 3 was planned around a two-way phone conversation, relying primarily on dialogue and reaction shots. Scene 4 was planned as a largely visual, dialogue-light scene built on the protagonist's physical actions and a single closing line.

3.5 Shot Planning

Shot planning for the film prioritised close and medium shots capable of conveying the protagonist's emotional state, given that the film relies heavily on internal, character-driven storytelling rather than wide action.

3.6 Production Process

The production process involved shooting each of the four planned scenes in sequence, following the shot plan established during pre-production.

3.7 Camera and Visual Approach

iPhone 16 e is the device used for capturing. The visual approach favoured intimate framing during the protagonist's emotional scenes (Scenes 1, 2 and 4) to draw the viewer into his internal experience, while Scene 3's phone conversation was framed to emphasise the moment of revelation.

3.8 Acting and Performance

The protagonist's performance was central to communicating the film's emotional arc, given the limited dialogue available across the four scenes. Performance choices needed to convey grief, anger and destructive intent in Scenes 1 and 2 without over-explaining through dialogue, and then convey surprise, emotional vulnerability and resolve in Scenes 3 and 4.

3.9 Location and Setting

Each scenes have be shot in an indoor environment of desi Indian house.

3.10 Props and Visual Elements

Key recurring props in the film include the protagonist's phone, used in Scenes 1 and 3; the cigarette and drugs associated with his destructive coping, used in Scenes 2 and 4; and the photograph of his deceased friend, which recurs across Scenes 2 and 4 as a visual anchor for his grief and, later, his resolve.

3.11 Scene-wise Production

Production of each scene followed the plan established during pre-production, with Scene 2's montage requiring multiple short takes to be shot and later assembled during editing, while Scenes 1, 3 and 4 were shot as more continuous dramatic beats.

3.12 Post-Production

Post-production for Side Effects consisted primarily of editing the shot footage into the film's final sequence using Cap-Cut, including assembling the Scene 2 montage, timing the dialogue-driven scenes, and finishing with the title-card reveal Side Effects over the closing cut to black.

3.13 Video Editing Using Cap Cut

Cap-Cut was used as the sole video-editing tool for Side Effects. The editing process involved importing the raw footage, arranging it according to the four-scene structure, trimming shots for pacing, and adding the closing title card.

3.14 Editing Workflow

The editing workflow proceeded scene by scene. Scene 1 was assembled first to establish the film's opening emotional tone, followed by the Scene 2 montage, which required careful trimming to compress several distinct actions into a brief but legible sequence. Scene 3 was edited to preserve the natural rhythm of the phone conversation, and Scene 4 was edited to let the protagonist's final actions play out with minimal cutting, preserving the emotional weight of the realization.

3.15 Cuts, Transitions and Pacing

Pacing was treated as a central editing concern given the film's short runtime. Scene 2's montage uses faster cuts to convey the intensity and repetition of the protagonist's destructive behaviour, while Scene 4 uses slower, more deliberate cuts to give the moment of realization room to land.

3.16 Visual Continuity

Visual continuity was maintained primarily through the recurring photograph prop, which appears in both the destructive-coping montage and the final realization scene, visually linking the protagonist's grief to his eventual transformation.

3.17 Audio, Dialogue and Music

The film's audio consists of the dialogue delivered in Scenes 1 and 3 and the protagonist's single line in Scene 4.

Table 3.1 Production Stages Overview

Stage	Key Activities
Pre-Production	Script finalisation, scene planning, shot planning
Production	Shooting of Scenes 1–4, including the Scene 2 montage
Post-Production	Editing, assembly, pacing and title card in CapCut

CHAPTER 4

SCENE ANALYSIS AND FILM EVALUATION

4.1 Introduction

This chapter provides a scene-by-scene analysis of *SIDE EFFECTS*, followed by an evaluation of the finished film in terms of its representation of the protagonist's emotional journey, its overall message, and the outcomes and limitations of the project.

4.2 Scene 1 – The Loss

Scene 1 establishes the film's inciting incident through a single phone call informing the protagonist that his best friend has been murdered. The protagonist's response "Why did you leave me alone?" immediately establishes his grief and sense of abandonment. By keeping this scene brief and direct, the film avoids dwelling on exposition and instead moves quickly into the emotional consequences that form the true subject of the story.



Figure 3.1 Scene 1 – The Loss

4.3 Scene 2 – The Side Effects

Scene 2 uses a montage to compress the protagonist's descent into destructive coping: smoking, drug use, intense physical training and repeated viewing of his friend's photograph. His declaration "I won't let his death go unanswered. I'll take revenge." marks the point at which his grief has hardened into a concrete, destructive intention. This scene gives the film its title, dramatizing the literal "side effects" of unprocessed grief.



Figure 3.2 Scene 2 – The Side Effects

4.4 Scene 3 – The Unexpected Call

Scene 3 introduces the turning point of the story: a phone call from a film director who reveals that the protagonist's deceased friend had always wanted to become a director and had wanted the protagonist to be part of that dream. This revelation reframes the protagonist's understanding of his friend's legacy and interrupts his trajectory toward revenge, offering him an alternative outlet for his grief.



Figure 3.3 Scene 3 – The Unexpected Call

4.5 Scene 4 – Realization

Scene 4 delivers the film's climax and resolution through action rather than dialogue. The protagonist looks at the cigarette and drugs, then at his friend's photograph, before discarding the former and declaring, "Your dream will live on through me." This single gesture replacing the instruments of his destructive coping with the pursuit of his friend's dream completes his transformation and delivers the film's moral.



Figure 3.4 Scene 4 – Realization

4.6 Character Transformation

The protagonist's transformation across the film's four scenes moves from a settled emotional state, through grief- and anger-driven destructive behaviour, to purposeful resolve. This arc is communicated almost entirely through action and a small number of pointed lines, demonstrating that a complete character transformation can be achieved within a short runtime when each scene is built around a clear emotional function.

4.7 Emotional Progression

The film's emotional progression follows the sequence identified in Chapter 2: loss, grief, anger, destructive behaviour, revenge, unexpected opportunity, realization, purpose and transformation. Each of the four scenes corresponds to one or more stages of this progression, giving the film a clear and legible emotional through-line despite its brevity.

4.8 Representation of Grief and Anger

Grief and anger are represented in the film primarily through the protagonist's behaviour rather than through dialogue his declaration of revenge in Scene 2 and his destructive coping mechanisms give concrete, visual form to emotions that might otherwise remain internal and difficult to dramatize within a short runtime.

4.9 Representation of Destructive Coping

The montage in Scene 2 represents destructive coping through three specific behaviours smoking, drug use and intense physical training alongside the recurring image of the friend's

photograph. Together, these choices depict grief curdling into self-harm and a fixation on revenge, setting up the contrast with the protagonist's eventual transformation in Scene 4.

4.10 Turning Pain into Purpose

The mechanism by which the protagonist turns his pain into purpose is the director's revelation that his friend had dreamed of becoming a filmmaker and had wanted the protagonist to share in that dream. This detail transforms an abstract idea "turn pain into purpose" into a concrete narrative device: the protagonist does not simply decide to feel better, but is given a specific, meaningful outlet through which to honour his friend.

4.11 Significance of the Ending

The ending's significance lies in its restraint: rather than resolving the story through revenge or through an explicit statement of the film's moral, it resolves through a quiet physical gesture discarding the cigarette and drugs followed by a single line of dialogue. This understated resolution allows the film's message to emerge through action, consistent with the protagonist's largely dialogue-light characterisation.

4.12 Overall Message of the Film

The overall message of Side Effects is that destructive responses to grief anger, addiction, revenge are understandable but ultimately harmful "side effects" of loss, and that a person's pain can instead be redirected into something constructive when given a meaningful outlet or purpose. The film delivers this message without explicit narration, relying instead on its visual and dramatic structure.

4.13 Project Outcome

The project succeeded in producing a complete 3–5 minute short film that dramatizes a full emotional arc from loss through destructive coping to purposeful transformation using a compact four-scene structure, minimal dialogue and a montage sequence edited in Cap-Cut.

4.14 Challenges and Limitations

Producing a complete emotional arc within a 3–5 minute runtime presented the general challenge of balancing narrative clarity with brevity, particularly in Scene 2, where several distinct destructive behaviours needed to be conveyed quickly without becoming visually cluttered.

4.15 Learning Outcomes

The project provided practical experience across the full short-film pipeline from concept and script development through shot planning, production and Cap-Cut-based post-production editing and reinforced the value of visual and action-driven storytelling as a means of conveying character emotion and thematic message within a constrained runtime.

Table 4.1 Scene Objectives and Emotional Function

Scene	Objective	Emotional Function
Scene 1 – The Loss	Establish the inciting incident	Loss, grief, abandonment
Scene 2 – The Side Effects	Depict destructive coping	Anger, addiction, desire for revenge
Scene 3 – The Unexpected Call	Introduce the turning point	Surprise, reconsideration
Scene 4 – Realization	Deliver resolution and transformation	Realization, purpose, resolve

Table 4.2 Learning Outcomes

Area	Outcome
Scriptwriting	Structuring a complete emotional arc within a strict short-film runtime
Production Planning	Translating a script into scene- and shot-level plans
Editing	Assembling a montage and pacing scenes using CapCut
Storytelling	Communicating theme and character change primarily through action

CHAPTER 5

CONCLUSION

5.1 Conclusion

Side Effects is a 3–5 minute drama that traces a protagonist’s journey from the sudden loss of his best friend, through destructive grief-driven behaviour, to a purposeful transformation prompted by the discovery of his friend’s unfulfilled dream. Through a compact four-scene structure, minimal dialogue and a montage sequence, the film delivers its stated moral that grief and anger can destroy a person, but turning pain into purpose can give life a new meaning using action and visual storytelling rather than explicit narration.

5.2 Achievement of Objectives

The project achieved its stated objectives: a complete script was written and structured to convey the full emotional arc within the intended runtime; the script was translated into a scene- and shot-level production plan; the four core scenes were shot and directed; and the footage was edited in Cap-Cut into a finished short film that communicates its intended theme.

5.3 Key Takeaways

The project demonstrates that a short runtime does not preclude a complete emotional arc, provided that each scene is designed around a clear narrative and emotional function. It also demonstrates the effectiveness of montage as a technique for compressing multiple related behaviours in this case, destructive coping into a brief but legible sequence.

5.4 Limitations

As discussed in Chapter 4, the project’s principal limitation lies in the inherent difficulty of conveying a nuanced emotional journey within a strict 3–5 minute runtime, which limits the space available for character development beyond the protagonist.

5.5 Final Conclusion

Side Effects demonstrates that a carefully structured short film can deliver a complete, resonant emotional journey and a clear social message within a brief runtime, fulfilling the project’s central creative and technical objectives.